

**DJI Mavic Air 2**

The Mavic Air 2 will come with many improvements over the original, including better sensors. <https://digit.in/may20-51>

**WhatsApp group video**

With a new update, upto 8 people can now have a group video calls on Whatsapp. <https://digit.in/may20-52>



VIRTUAL TOURIST

Trotting the globe using VR

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

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ith the global outbreak of COVID-19, regular travel is definitely off the cards for the

foreseeable future, however, virtual escapism within the safe confines of your home is open to just about everyone. All you need is a working internet connection and a VR headset. There's also no need to fret even if you do not have a VR headset since most Virtual Reality tours come with the option of simply moving around your device to gain a 360-degree view of the place you're visiting virtually. VR

tours are even beneficial past the lockdown phase brought on by the novel coronavirus since they allow individuals to visit sites and attractions that may possibly be out of their budget, such as the Colosseum in Rome, or ones that are simply too crowded, such as the Taj Mahal in India. There are also some inaccessible attractions around the world such as the inner chambers of the Pyramids of Giza. Here, public visitation is prohibited since the chambers have low oxygen levels. These inaccessible areas can possibly be examined by tourists via VR in the future.

The very first 'virtual tour' dates back to the year 1994, however, it was not one of the VR-enabled virtual tours that we have today. It was a 3D reconstruction of the Dudley Castle in England, officially inaugurated by Queen Elizabeth II. Today, the

technologically-aided virtual tours are accessed by tourists to visit locations, by students to explore the heritage and historical sites, by libraries and museums, and even realtors selling houses. Recently, there has been some progress made in utilising VR to view endangered sites, thereby relieving the stress on the land incurred by frequenting tourists. VR has also made it possible to view the ancient ruins in all their glory. However, you need to be there in person at these sites to view them in their ancient form. Something to put into your bucket list for when the lockdown ends?

VISITING ENDANGERED SITES

In 2018, Google partnered with 3D laser scanning nonprofit CyArk to help preserve historical sites all over the world. These sites are usually ones that are on the brink of irreversible damage due to human intervention and natural disasters. The effort, dubbed Open Heritage Project, uses CyArk's laser-scanning to capture a vast amount of data at the historical site. The site is then recreated virtually so that it can be visited from the confines of one's home on a computer, mobile phone or through a VR headset. CyArk's mission is to successfully capture as many historical monuments and sites as possible before they fall prey to natural and man-made degradation over the years. They also plan to capture inaccessible locations such as the Chavín de Huántar, a religious site in Peru which is situated almost 4,000 metres above the ground. All of this is accomplished by utilising a laser-scanning system called LIDAR paired with high-resolution photographic images captured by DSLRs, or in some cases, drones.

One example is the Ananda Ok Kyaung temple situated in Bagan, Myanmar. This site eventually collapsed due to an earthquake in 2016. Fortunately, CyArk successfully laser-mapped the site before the disaster occurred and has even released an in-